

Hybrid-Casual Mobile Games Analysis: Mini Merge Champions and Lucky Adventure

Case Study

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1. Introduction

This case study analyzes two Hybrid-Casual Action mobile games published by Rollic Games: Mini Merge Champions and Lucky Adventure.

Before analyzing the games individually, I first examined the key metrics including ROAS, Retention, CPI and Playtime and ranked them based on importance.

I also researched Rollic Game's perspective and analyzed current market benchmarks to better understand the company's publishing approach and industry standards.

Using this framework, I then analyzed both games through direct gameplay experience by evaluating their core gameplay loops, progression systems, monetization structures and engagement mechanics. Finally, I identified the major retention barriers affecting each game, estimated their potential D30 retention performance and proposed improvements focused on retention and monetization.

2. Design Elements

1.ROAS (Return on Ad Spend): ROAS is the most fundamental metric that measures the return on money spent on ads. It is calculated by the formula $ROAS = ARPU / CPI$. This formula means that higher user revenue and lower acquisition costs directly impact better ROAS. I have placed ROAS at the top of the list because a publisher works with many studios and games but has limited time and budget. When publisher asks the question "If I invest in this game, will I get my money back? ", the answer lies in ROAS metric. Also, all other metrics eventually serve to improve ROAS, as shown in Figure 1.

2.Retention: Retention is the metric that shows the percentage of players who return to a game after a specific period. For example, a D1 Retention of %30 means that 30 out of 100 players returned the game the day after installing it. High retention indicates that players find the core loop entertaining and feel motivated to progress. I have ranked Retention second because high retention leads to higher LTV, allowing for a higher CPI tolerance. A game with strong retention can remain profitable even CPI increases, as a loyal player base continues to generate revenue.

3.CPI (Cost Per Install): CPI is the cost of getting a user to download the game. While a lower CPI is advantage for attracting more players at a lower cost, it is not sufficient on its own. LTV (Lifetime Value), the total revenue a user generates during their time in the game, is directly linked to CPI. For a game to be profitable, LTV must be higher than CPI. Otherwise, it results in loss. I have ranked CPI third because a very low CPI can sometimes bring in low quality users, which negatively impacts Retention and ROAS in the long run.

4.Playtime: Playtime is defined as the total amount of time a player spends in the game. This metric indicates how engaging the game's content is. While high playtime is generally a positive sign, low playtime can signal issues with user onboarding or a weak core loop. I have ranked Playtime fourth because even if a player has high playtime on their first day of playing, it holds little value if they do not return on the second day. Playtime only becomes truly meaningful when combined with strong retention.

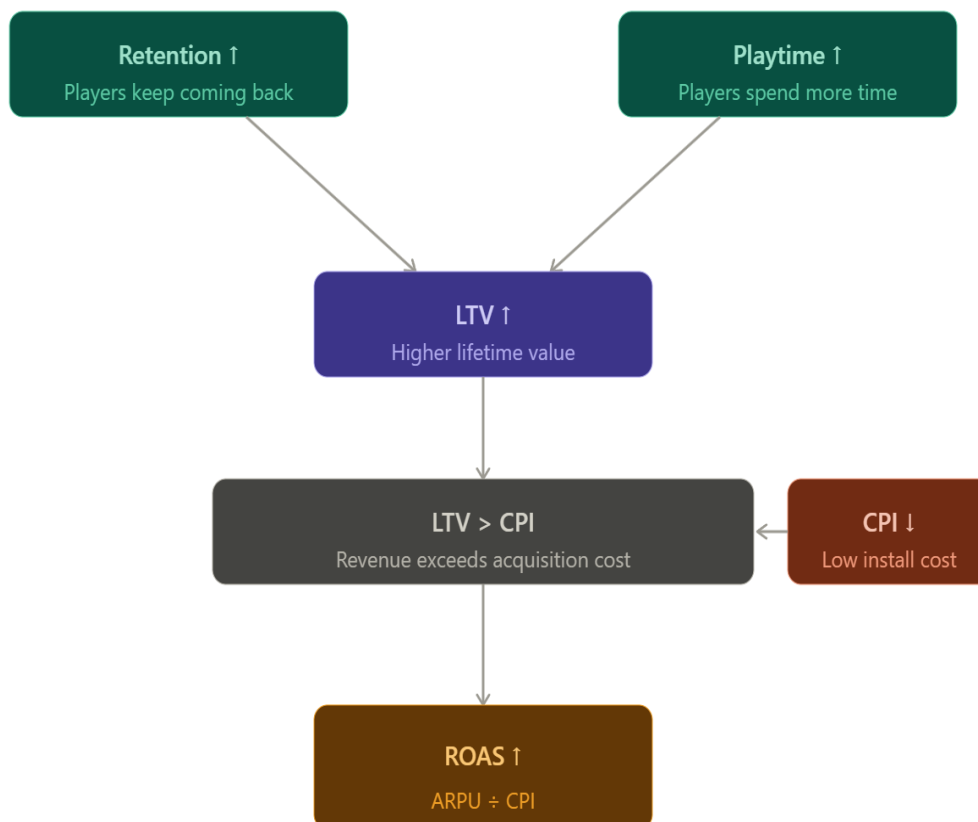


Figure 1: How key metrics shape ROAS

3. Rollic's Hybrid Evolution and Market Standards

Both Mini Merge Champions and Lucky Adventure are Hybrid-Casual games. So, I conducted research about hybrid-casual game benchmarks and Rollic's strategic shift from Hyper-Casual to Hybrid-Casual games to better understand industry standards.

3.1 Rollic's Approach

Since 2022, Rollic has undergone a strategic evolution, transitioning from a Hyper-Casual to Hybrid-Casual model where 70-80% of revenue driven by In App Purchases. I found an interview on this subject in Deconstructor of Fun channel. In this interview, CEO Burak Vardal describes this shift not as a forced business model change, but as a 'product consequence' of making better, deeper games. Rollic's approach involves maintaining rapid prototyping while building deeper loops designed for months-long retention.

3.2 Market Analysis

Both Mini Merge Champions and Lucky Adventure compete in the Hybrid-Casual category, one of the fastest growing sectors in the mobile market. According to Sensor Tower's 'The State of Mobile 2026' report the industry benchmarks for this genre are:

- Day-1 Retention: 40.11%
- Day-7 Retention: 16.08%
- Day-30 Retention: 5.86%

These figures suggest that a D30 retention rate around 6% is considered a strong benchmark for hybrid-casual games.

4. Mini Merge Champions

In this section, I analyzed the game Mini Merge Champions. Found the possible retention barriers and estimated a D30 retention. Also, for the answer to question 2, I suggested D30 retention upgrade.

4.1 About the Game

Mini Merge Champions is a Hybrid Action mobile game developed by Popcore GmbH under Rollic Games that blends strategy, puzzle and combat elements. For this case study, I played through first 9 chapters to conduct a deeper analysis and provide a more accurate D30 retention estimation.

The game features seamless onboarding experience, using text pop-ups and directional arrows to introduce new mechanics step by step. The core loop takes place on 6x6 grid where heroes dropped from above and matched in groups of 3 or more to merge into stronger units. Once the given move count finishes the squad automatically battles incoming enemies. I identified the core loop as Merge → Battle → Win Coins → Upgrade Heroes.

Beyond the core loop, the game offers a hero collection system with rarity tiers and an equipment system. Engagement is supported with daily and weekly rewards, a league leaderboard, PvP Arena and a roguelike Tower mode. The level design provides balanced difficulty curve and at later stages encourages players to revisit previous chapter to grind coins and upgrades. The games monetization is based on both In App Purchases and Ad revenue. Visually, the game has colorful-cute art style and changing environmental themes across the chapters.

4.2 Retention Barriers

I have identified possible friction points where players are most likely to churn before reaching day 30 and listed them in order of importance:

- **Excessive Ad Dependency:** The heavy reliance on rewarded ads for core mechanics constantly interrupts the game flow leading to early-stage player fatigue.
- **Unreachable Events:** The Legendary Pirates event is introduced as early as day 2 but requires 1.000.000 coins within 7-day window, nearly impossible goal for new players who are spending all their coins on essential hero upgrades. These types of events may create frustration and a sense of exclusion.
- **Repetitive Content:** While environmental themes change across chapters, the core mechanics and puzzle patterns remain largely identical. This may lead players to a loss of curiosity.
- **Limited Social Interaction:** The game lacks fundamental social features such as friend system, direct player-to-player interaction or the ability to team up. The absence of community element makes the experience solitary.

4.3 D30 Retention Estimation

Upon analyzing the game, I observed over dependency on In App Advertising, that disrupts its intended hybrid balance. Some of the most important features of the game such as, x2 speed, extra moves and boss summoning are offered through watching ads. This indicates that despite promising hybrid model, the game remains heavily dependent on ad revenue. Additionally, while checking the App Store page, I realized the game has not received any updates since July 2025. Considering Rollic's approach, the project was likely abandoned because it didn't reach the desired metrics.

Based on the game's progression depth, collection systems, PvP feature and additional game mode called Tower, Mini Merge Champions likely performed around or slightly above the hybrid-casual benchmark in terms of D30 retention.

However, despite potentially achieving a competitive retention level, the retention barriers listed in Section 4.2 most likely prevented the game from sustaining player engagement long enough to meet Rollic's publishing standards, which are likely set higher than industry average given its position as one of the top publishers in the Hybrid-Casual space.

Considering both the engagement systems and the project's apparent discontinuation, I would estimate the game's D30 retention to be in the range of 6-8%.

4.4 Improving D30 Retention: Redesigning the Legendary Pirates Event

Of the retention barriers identified in Section 4.2, I chose the unreachable events to offer an improvement in D30 retention.

The Legendary Pirates event introduces 5 Legendary heroes. Each purchasable separately at prices ranging from 95.000 to 470.000 coins or all together for 1.000.000 coins within a 7 day window. This event appeared on my second day of playing, a point where I had barely 12.000 coins and was spending everything on essential hero upgrades. Introducing such an expensive and time-limited event this early creates excitement but immediately turns into frustration when players realize it is completely out of reach and only option is paying real money for coins, which is an expensive option.

If I were the game designer, I would transform this 7-day event into a 30-day progressive event with two clear paths. Players who want immediate access can purchase Legendary heroes directly with real money (this remains an expensive option). Players who prefer to earn them for free can progress through daily logins over 30 days. When they discover they can earn the same content completely for free they will feel motivated for long-term engagement.

The daily login rewards scale progressively. Starting with small amounts of coins on Day 1 and increasing in value each day, including energy, gems, Tower tickets and hero keys in later stages. The five Legendary heroes are unlocked as milestone rewards on Days 7, 14, 21, 28 and 30, from weakest to strongest. If a player misses a single day, they have an option to watch a rewarded ad to recover their streak and continue from where they left off. However, if they miss two consecutive days, their streak resets. They return to Day 1 but any Legendary heroes already earned are kept permanently. When they reach a milestone they have already claimed, the game awards blueprints instead, ensuring no reward is wasted.

Players who choose to purchase the Legendary Heroes instantly will not miss out on the free path's rewards either. Once they have already unlocked a hero through real money, reaching that hero's milestone day during 30-day login journey will award blueprints instead, allowing them to upgrade their Legendary Heroes further.

This structure transforms the event into both a monetization and a 30-day retention tool. Spenders get instant gratification. Free-to-play players get a clear, achievable goal that brings them back every single day.

To illustrate this redesign, I created a visual using AI as show in Figure 2. The left side shows the original in-game event screen, while the right side shows the image of the proposed design.



Figure 2: Current event UI (left) vs. Proposed redesign image (right).

5. Lucky Adventure

In this section, I analyzed the game Lucky Adventure. Found the possible retention barriers and estimated a D30 retention. Also, for the answer to question 3, I suggested an In App Purchase monetization improvement.

5.1 About the Game

Lucky Adventure is a Hybrid-Action mobile game published by Rollic Games that blends board game mechanics with RPG progression and risk-based mini games. For this case study, I played through first 3 chapters and analyzed the game.

The core loop is built around a dice-based board system. Players roll dice and land on different tiles, each triggering a unique mechanic. I identified the core loop as: Roll Dice → Land on Tile → Play Mini Games / Earn Rewards / Battle → Upgrade Character → Progress through the board.

The game features a wide variety of tile types, including Battle, Hero Roulette, Lucky Slot, Forge, Angel or Devil Offer and different kinds of mini games, each offering different risk/reward mechanics. Combat is stat based, with the outcome determined by the hero's attack, defense and HP values. The player's character is strengthened through equipment collected from chests and stat boosts earned from tiles.

Beyond the core loop, the game offers deep meta layer including a Town Building System that boosts rewards across tiles, a Memory Card collection system, a Pet system and a Destiny stone mechanic. Engagement is further supported through daily and weekly missions, a Battle Pass called Quest Pass, daily login rewards and multiple simultaneous events such as Kingdom Party, Heroes Choice, Thief and Plinko event. Monetization combines In-App Purchases with Rewarded Ads. Visually game features colorful fantasy art style.

5.2 Retention Barriers

I have identified possible friction points where players are most likely to churn before reaching day 30 and listed them in order of importance:

- **Energy System:** Energy exhausts very quickly due to the fast-paced nature of the game. Each dice roll consumes one energy; since some tiles resolve instantly, a full energy bar can be exhausted in under 20 minutes.
- **Overwhelming Complexity:** The game introduces a large number of systems in short period. Mini games, Buildings, Forging, Memory Cards, Destiny Stones and more. The onboarding feels complex and may leave some players confused.
- **Hard to Pass Chapters:** Chapter bosses can create difficulty spikes that leave players stuck for extended periods. During my playthrough, I spent a considerable amount of time in Chapter 2 boss and ultimately had to purchase energy to progress. This possesses a serious churn risk for players who are not willing to spend.
- **Mini Game Loss Frustration:** Risk-based mini games such as Above or Below, Flip Coin and Rock Paper Scissors operate on an all-or-nothing loss mechanic. Losing everything in a single wrong move creates a frustrating experience that may push players away.

5.3 D30 Retention Estimation

Lucky Adventure operates as a well-balanced hybrid model. Rewarded ads are optional and limited to daily bonuses such as energy, gems, coins and gear summons. Interstitial ads appear during gameplay but their frequency is low. This suggests IAP is the primary revenue driver.

Lucky Adventure's App Store Page reflects recent updates as of February 2026, including major core gameplay overhaul, balance and quality adjustments. The game currently holds a 4.6 rating with 1700+ reviews, indicating strong player satisfaction. However, the absence of updates over the past three months raises some uncertainty about the game's current development status.

The retention barriers identified in Section 5.2 do pose churn risks. However, the game's deep meta layer and active events provide strong long-term engagement hooks that work against these barriers.

Based on the game's strong player ratings, deep progression systems and well-balanced monetization, I would estimate Lucky Adventure's D30 retention to be in the range of 7-9%, above the hybrid-casual benchmarks of 5.86% and slightly above the estimated range of Mini Merge Champions at 6-8%.

5.4 Improving IAP Monetization: Multiplier Subscription Model

Lucky Adventure features a variable multiplier system that boosts all tile rewards when active. However, in its current form, the multiplier activates temporarily under unclear conditions, making it difficult for players to understand its value. The game also offers a separate Energy Subscription, a 14-day pass that provides daily energy bonuses for 10\$.

If I were the game designer, I would merge the existing Energy Subscription and the Multiplier system into a tiered subscription model, replacing them entirely. This redesign would be introduced at a key frustration point, for example, when a player has been stuck on the same chapter boss for an extended period. After this initial introduction, the subscription panel would remain accessible as a visible shortcut on the main screen.

I would introduce a 1-hour free trial upon first encounter. This allows players to directly experience how significantly the multiplier affects character progression. Gaining more coins, tokens, forge materials and faster stat upgrades. Once the trial ends, players who felt the difference will be far more motivated to purchase.

With this redesign:

- 3-day pass: x1.5 multiplier for \$4
- 7-day pass: x2 multiplier + 35 daily energy for \$8
- 14-day pass: x2.5 multiplier + 45 daily energy for \$10

In the current game, activating x2 multiplier consumes double energy and x3 multiplier consumes triple. In this redesign the 3-day pass reduces energy consumption to x1, the 7-day and 14-day passes maintain x2 energy consumption. Additionally, if players feel they are consuming too much energy, they can deactivate the multiplier and continue playing at the standard rate.

This energy balance was designed intentionally. Knowing the base energy cap is 25, players on the 3-day pass with x1 energy consumption can play 25 dice rolls per full bar. Players on the 7-day pass receive 35 bonus daily energy, bringing their effective total to 60, they can play 30 dice rolls with x2 energy consumption. Similarly, the 14-day pass provides 45 bonus energy for total of 70, players can play 35 dice rolls at x2 consumption.

The three-tier structure creates a natural spending ladder. Players who enjoy the trial may start with the 3-day pass and upgrade to longer options as they experience the benefit. An active subscription also supports retention, as players with an ongoing pass have a daily reason to open the game.

This proposed subscription model was inspired by Monthly Card structure in Capybara Go, a commercially successful game in the same genre as Lucky Adventure. To illustrate this redesign, I created a visual using AI as show in Figure 3, comparing the proposed model with the original Monthly Card in Capybara Go.



Figure 3: Monthly Card system from Capybara Go! (left) vs. Proposed Subscription Model Image (right)

6. Conclusion

Both Mini Merge Champions and Lucky Adventure demonstrate strong Hybrid-Casual foundations through progressive systems, engagement mechanics and monetization design. But this case study highlights successful games require not only engaging core loops but also sustainable retention systems and player-friendly monetization strategies.

While Mini Merge Champions has a solid puzzle foundation, it needs more ‘breathing room’ for Free-to-Play players to prevent early burnout. On the other hand, Lucky Adventure’s depth is its greatest strength, yet it requires a more structured spending ladder to convert engagement into revenue.

The proposed changes focus on shifting the player’s experience from forced interaction to rewarded loyalty. By implementing long term retention tools and clear value-driven subscriptions, we can create a sustainable ecosystem that meets Rollic’s high publishing standards.

7. References

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